



b. 1971 · American entrepreneur, founder of Spanx.

"Failure is the best classroom."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Blakely's career embodies the conviction that resilience and a willingness to fail — not perfect resources — build durable companies.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

She built Spanx from a small personal investment into a major brand without outside funding, learning through repeated failure and persistence.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

She anchors the resilient-builder perspective in Unit 7's scaling Slibraries — a counterweight to pure speed-and-capital strategies.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

Her example operationalises as treating failure as a classroom, building grit deliberately, and not letting the absence of resources excuse inaction.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

Individual-founder lessons generalise imperfectly, and survivorship bias attends any single success story.

ENDURING IMPACT

Blakely became a prominent example of bootstrapped, resilient entrepreneurship and a widely cited founder voice.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 7)

Peter Thiel · Giant 18

Reid Hoffman · Giant 29

Geoffrey Moore · Giant 30

Sangeet Choudary · Giant 31

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Blakely, S. (2021) interviews and public talks on building Spanx.

Bhide, A. (2000) The Origin and Evolution of New Businesses. Oxford: OUP.